



Fixing the Play Store

A post by a developer on what can be done to fix the difficult process of discovering new apps for droids. <https://digit.in/aug20-25>



r/Android app store

A community made curated app store for Android users, which includes paid apps as well. <https://digit.in/aug20-26>

Boo man hates the Android play store

Why is navigating the Play Store such a trudge?

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With the advent of smartphones, smartphone design has settled down to the slate design, though we do at times miss the candybar, taco, clamshell and compass box form factors that once filled the pages of this magazine. No matter how many cores or cameras you pack in, the most utility that you get from your device boils down to the apps that you have installed. Therefore, it is necessary to install good apps. On the App Store, new apps are surprisingly easy to find. The first tab contains daily listers of curated content. There are deep dives into the features of individual apps, and how to use the more advanced features. There are interviews with developers explaining the decisions behind the features in the apps. There are topical listers, such as skill building apps for the lockdown, or apps for families to keep their children engaged. This curated section is the first thing that is shown to the user, and does a good job of surfacing hidden gems, and also includes hand picked apps that might not have too many installs. There is also an app of the day and game of the day section, which changes every day.

Now let us look at the Play Store. The first thing see are religious and self help books. Then comes a bar of Bollywood films, with of course the sleazy ones being showcased. Google did try to come up with curated lists, but

finding that is almost an easter egg. It is called Editor's Pick, and seems to be a long abandoned half hearted attempt at curating content. The first lister that you find is a collection of Escape Room titles that was put up in June 2019. There are about 15 such listers, and that is all that the editors of the Play Store have to recommend. There is a recommended for you section that presumably uses some kind of broken AI, but if it works for you, let us know!

The Top Free Apps and the Top Paid Apps are also full of junk, clones and outright scams. Poonam Pandey TV? The Secret to Money by Rhonda Bryne? Really?! When it comes to games, the top charts are full of bad match 3 titles, clones of 2048, and like 10 different versions of Ludo. Android seems to be aggressively hiding away all the good apps on the store, instead of taking the effort to surface the content to the end user. In the end, both the user and developers are harmed by this nonchalant and lackadaisical approach. Then comes the horror gallery that are the app descriptions for the bad decisions. Here is a sample: "Sobbing, baby cry, adult weeping, screaming in pain, this free app has them all!" When you cater to the lowest common denominator there are some really bizarre trends that emerge. Did you know that there are a whole bunch of electric razor simulator apps on the Play Store? These are apparently some kind of prank apps, which are especially cruel in times when people are already doing traumatic things to their hair, and forced to get haircuts from their partners. Then there are the sub-

scription services. Apple Arcade has a number of cool exclusives such as Sonic Racing, Shinsekai: Into the Depths, and Frogger in Toyland. Play Pass on the other hand offers titles that are already available in the store anyway such as Limbo and Reigns: GOT. Additionally, Play Pass is not available in India. The situation may change with the publishers that Google has on boarded onto for Stadia, but I am not too hopeful, given that Google has had ten years to fix the Play Store! The situation has grown so drastic, that the users have had to fill the very noticeable gap in curation. The users on r/android subreddit have put together their own lists of curated, hand picked android apps, via a wiki they maintain for that purpose. AppAffinity does a better job of recommending new apps based on your installs than the Play Store.

The very least that Google can do is fix these small problems, but there are other systemic problems as well. Bot

farms are used to rig the rating system, the Google Play Games service that is used to share stats and achievements with friends uses Google+, which is a discontinued service, and this is a service that you need to install on your phone even though it does not work and is absolutely pointless! This is a requirement even for offline games. Chances are you might not even be aware that this service

exists. The alternative by Apple, Game Centre works just fine across games, and even allows for easy matchmaking with your contacts. There seems to be no quality control whatsoever, and considering the many times when apps with problematic security issues have been purged from the store, there really needs to be some gatekeeping as well, apart from focused efforts on surfacing quality apps to the end user. This is a mess that Android has been perpetually stuck in, and has shown no strong efforts towards fixing. 



I hate it, thanks.